Rhea Madhogarhia

Prof. Sevda Numanbayraktaroglu

Cultural Schemas Influence on Emotional Expression and Socialization

In, "Cognitive Anthropology", D'Andrade explains how schema theory helps us understand how cultural knowledge is organized and how cultural contexts are developed and subsequently reinforced. D'Andrade claims that schemas are, "cognitive structure[s] through which interpretations about the world are made" (D'Andrade, 52). Our interpretations of the world guide our behavior, our language, and how we react to and interact with others. So, understanding different cultures' guiding schemas, which D'Andrade calls "master motives", is important for uncovering the difference between emotional expression in those cultures (D'Andrade, 55). It is not as simple as a schema "causing" an emotional expression; schemas can be constituted of other schemas, so while emotions are influenced by cultural schemas, D'Andrade mentions that, for Americans, feeling the emotion of love, is a master motive. In other words, the cultural context can shape how emotions are experienced and expressed, while, simultaneously, emotions inform the cultural context and schema. Ultimately, it is the directive and motivational force of cultural schemas that guides an emotional experience that both constitutes and is constituted by a cultural context.

Wikan's study of Balinese morality and health care demonstrates the impact of a cultural schema with a "great directive force" (D'Andrade. 56). Wikan corrects the common misinterpretation of composure for lack of empathy in Balinese reactions to loss: "What we are seeing here is action guided by Balinese concepts of health care, morality and compassion" (298, Wikan). Wikan's work elucidates the fact that emotional expression in Balinese culture is an "indicator of health"; for the Balinese, sadness is sickness, happiness is health, and health (which is in turn, emotion) is a collective concern for the society (Wikan, 300-301). The directive force here is the health and safety of members of the society. This creates, "emotion work", which, "seems persistently to compel and motivate action; is explicitly

perceived as preventing illness; and… points to the way certain emotions are linked with specified somatic ailments" (299, Wikan). To be happy is to be healthy, so the Balinese must work to be happy to ensure the health of their community. Wikan even says that Balinese management of emotions is a "moral social obligation", so, "by deliberately making oneself appear, or being made to appear, cheerful (*girang*) or happy (*gembira*) feelings conducive to health are nurtured" (Wikan, 302). To be a good and moral person in the Balinese cultural context is to ensure the health of the community and self. Thus, revisiting the Balinese reaction to loss, a widow's friends will nurse health in the widow by surrounding her with their own healthy (happy and laughter-filled) hearts; to show sorrow for the widow would be to surround her with sickness (Wikan, 299-300).

Lutz and Briggs found a similar cultural concern for impacting one's emotional state within Ifaluk and Inuit parental roles. Lutz's anthropological study of the Ifaluk people of Micronesia found that, "emotions [were] assumed…to be the primary source of human motivation" (Lutz, 247). With emotion constituting much of the Ifaluk's cultural context, Lutz sought to explore how this cultural schema was constituted; how are children inaugurated into this cultural schema? She found that the socialization of emotions was a parent-driven process - to create a "good" child was to raise a child that could appropriately feel emotions of *metagu* and *song* (Lutz, 256). To raise such a child and socialize untranslatable, culturally specific feelings served the community by maintaining the cultural schema, or "motivational framework", that helped to maintain customs of order, obedience, and cooperation that is integral to social control and relationships in Ifaluk culture (Lutz, 250). Lutz continues, "What we term emotion is seen by the Ifaluk as relational, and as a product of social interaction" (Lutz, 250-51). Here we see emotion as a product, which actions performed in the cultural context aim to create, but also a process by which the cultural schema is created and followed. Therefore, the value assigned to a "calm" and appropriately emotive individual in Ifaluk society instills a "hyper awareness" of the cultural context which is informed by the management of emotion itself (Lutz, 254). Lutz summarizes this relationship succinctly, "Emotions are both the medium and the message of socialization" (260).

Similarly, Briggs' research among the Inuit community reveals a comparable emphasis on the socialization of emotions within parental roles. In her study, Briggs identifies how Inuit parents actively teach their children to regulate and express emotions through her account of the development of the feelings of *nallik*, *unga*, and *ilira* in a young Inuit girl named Chubby Maata. She notes that, "For Inuit, social order did not derive merely from following rules of expression; it depended on feeling the culturally appropriate emotions. As they saw it, emotions motivated behavior" (Briggs, 159). Her observations recorded parental teasings of Chubby Maata's actions to guide the learning of appropriate feelings of attachment, love, and ownership (Briggs, 162). One interaction, in which Chubby Maata's sister and father taught her to regulate her desire for milk in tea when the milk did not belong to her, highlights the importance and effort made in Inuit society to teach culturally praised behavior. These teachings also elucidate which emotions a community finds appropriate in specific situations, revealing information about the culture's conceptions of human nature, how social and family relationships are structured, and how other individuals have learned to embody cultural values. The embodiment of the cultural context is the emotional response to any situation, which is both the product and producer of the parental teachings.

Thus, the studies conducted by Lutz, Briggs, and Wikan collectively underscore the profound influence of cultural schemas on emotional expression and socialization processes within cultural contexts. From the Balinese emphasis on emotional expression as an indicator of health and morality to the Ifaluk and Inuit practices of socializing emotions within parental roles, it becomes evident that cultural schemas not only shape how emotions are experienced and expressed but also serve as guiding frameworks for social interaction and behavior. Ultimately, these studies highlight the importance of understanding cultural schemas in uncovering the differences in emotional expression across cultures and how emotions serve as both the medium and message of socialization within specific cultural contexts.

Works Cited

Briggs, Jean L. “Emotions Have Many Faces: Inuit Lessons.” *Anthropologica*, vol. 42, no. 2, 2000, pp. 157–164. *Reflections on Anthropology in Canada*, https://doi.org/https://www.jstor.org/stable/25605984?origin=JSTOR-pdf.

D’Andrade, Roy G. “Cognitive Anthropology.” *New Directions in Psychological Anthropology*, Cambridge University Press, 1992, pp. 47–58.

Lutz, Catherine. “Parental goals, ethnopsychology, and the development of emotional meaning.” *Ethos*, vol. 11, no. 4, Dec. 1983, pp. 246–262, https://doi.org/10.1525/eth.1983.11.4.02a00040.

Wikan, Unni. “Managing the heart to brighten face and soul: Emotions in Balinese morality and health care.” *American Ethnologist*, vol. 16, no. 2, May 1989, pp. 294–312, https://doi.org/10.1525/ae.1989.16.2.02a00070.